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The Second Innings

After I hung up my spurs as the army chief on 30 September 2007, Rohini and I just relaxed for a few days and took stock of our personal matters. These had taken a back seat during my service career – things like personal correspondence, bank accounts, passports, housing, car loans and the like. During this period Rudrangshu Mukherjee from *The Telegraph* approached me to write for their op-ed page. I agreed to write one article every month. During my tenure as the army chief, I was requested by some organizations to receive their awards in appreciation of my services for the nation. I had politely declined their requests at that time citing exigencies of service. Having retired, I had no hesitation to say yes to such honours provided the organizations were non-political and reputed. Therefore, in October that year, I received the 'Sikh of the Year 2007' Award from the 'Sikh Forum International', at the famous Lincoln's Inn in London. Thereafter, we spent a few days with Vivek and his wife Anna, and their two lovely daughters, Anne-Tara and Marie-Sana, at their cosy home in the countryside in Normandy, France. We enjoyed this holiday like free birds soaking in the wonderful ambience of the French countryside.

The word retirement has never appealed to me. I look at life ahead as a batsman who is taking the crease for the second innings. For both Rohini and me there is no question of sitting on past laurels; we always try and find something constructive and meaningful to do. We came back to Delhi and got immersed in reorganizing our lives in the new milieu and environment. Golf came to our rescue and we tried to play as frequently as possible. It kept us sane and fit. One day around mid-November 2007, I